

tears of a parched god

A briny and cultish
adventure for **Level**
5 heroes



JACK WEIGHILL & EVAN DIAZ

WHAT'S GOING ON?

Travellers on the King's Reach Highway have been vanishing in droves, their emptied wagons and dead pack animals marred with ocean salt. On the banks of the Sea of Tears, a cult in pale robes weep, led by **Ado the Desiccated**—driven mad from indulging the Sea of Tears' brine. Ado believes that with enough tears from his followers, **Saar, She Who Mourns**, can be resurrected. With the power he has gained from the sea's waters, he has erected a great Tower of Salt, with which he imprisons his forced worshippers.

SECRETS

- The Sea of Tears was once the site of a great ritual. Its nature has been lost to time, but a side effect of it was the salinification of the sea.
- The sea gets its name from an ancient evil that once plagued the land: Saar, She Who Mourns, an elder evil of sorrow and misery.
- The cult of Saar seeks to spread the misery to all things great and small, living and dead.

QUEST HOOKS

- **Marla Homebrew**, innkeeper of the Valley's Rest is expecting her sister, Hilda, to return from Far Hope, but she hasn't arrived. Hilda travelled recently there to receive guidance from Lyra the Oracle. Has something happened to her?
- **Sir Alric**, Captain of the Far Hope City Guard, has noted several missing shipments from Merivale and instructs adventurers to uncover what has become of the merchants, their supplies, and the Golden Company soldiers protecting them. He points them toward Lyra for guidance.
- **Lyra, the Oracle**, receives a chilling vision of a thousand weeping souls knelt before a pillar of salt. The vision is a portent of the end times and points toward the Sea of Tears.

LOOT

- **Tearstone Droplet**. A teardrop-shaped sapphire. Gain 1 Wound to succeed on a failed save (3 uses).
- **Desiccate**. Utility cantrip, 1 Action. Touch a willing character, deal them 1 Wound, and bestow resistance to lightning damage for 1 hour. OR: Instantly remove all moisture from a small object (e.g., wet clothes, a scroll, a patch of ground).
- **Brine Staff**. Action: Summon a tiny salt crystal minion (size: 1d4) adjacent to you. It lasts for 10 minutes. 3 charges. Recharge: Bury in salt for 1 week.

TRAVELING ENCOUNTERS

- **Abandoned Wagon**. Run off the road and looted. 2 pack horses lie dead nearby, dry as bones. All is covered in briny residue. Bandits (3/hero) and Bandit Assassins (1/hero) rummage through the wreck: "Bog off!" they'll shout. If approached nonthreateningly, they may be willing to talk (DC 12 Influence). The bandits were recently ambushed on the road themselves by hooded madmen who made off with one of their boys. They've been scouring the road for evidence on where they might have taken him.
- **Salt Crystal**. Enormous column. Visible on its surface are moving, arcane scenes. Heroes who peer into it must make a DC 14 WIL save. Success: They see a vision of the Tower of Salt and learn a secret. Failure: They see only misery and take damage equal to 14—their save and become Dehydrated.

***Dehydrated:** Lose 1 Hit Die and suffer a –1 penalty to movement speed. Healing ends movement penalty.*

- **Escaped Captive**. Hightailing it up toward the heroes is a haggard man dressed in tattered, dark cloth. "They're right behind me! Please help me!" Cultists (2/hero) chase after him. He's the missing Bandit who escaped captivity. He saw a glimpse of a "white tower surrounded by crybabies."

ADVENTURE LOCATIONS

Weeping Worshippers. *Hundreds kneel, weeping before a great white tower.*

- Tears of salt have dried to their cheeks. Most are local travellers who, through choked tears, tell of being kidnapped and compelled to weep before the tower (powerful magic compels them to weep here).
- A shriveled corpse lies on the ground (a man who tried to escape shrivelled up and died).

Saline Protector. *Steps ascending to the tower are guarded by golems made of salt.*

- Salt Golems (1 for every 2 heroes) block tower entrance, they will attack any who try to go past. Clever thinking may permit heroes to pass without coming to blows. Anyone weeping gains advantage on Initiative or Influence checks against them.

SALT GOLEM LVL 5, LARGE **H** 40

Brittle. *Armor degrades when crit: Medium » None.*

Slam (2x). (Reach 2) 1d10 +5. *Advantage VS Dehydrated targets. On crit: Knockback 4, landing Prone.*

THE TOWER

Climbing the Salt Tower. *Heroes must make a DC 10 STR save each time they ascend to a new floor, each time they fail they become **Dehydrated**.*

Tower Ground Floor. *Gentle (disorienting) sobbing can be heard behind a closed **door**. Salt **stairs** lead further up the tower—toward a faint glow.*

- **Stairs.** Crunch disconcertingly. The party must succeed on 3 DC 12 skill checks to ascend safely. Each failure means that hero falls (1d6 damage), 3 failures and the stairs collapse entirely. Heavy heroes have disadvantage on the rolls (e.g., lots of armor).
- **Door.** Translucent stalagmites and stalactites of salt are scattered about the room, dripping water from the ceiling. *They weep softly.* Tending to them are several crazed Fanatics (1/hero). Heroes who hear the weeping of the crystals get -4 to their Initiative roll. A more substantial staircase is also in this room.
- **Loot: Bead of Absorption.** A small bead of glimmering magical salt. When touched to a liquid, you can have it instantly absorb up to 100 gallons of that liquid. 1/Safe Rest.

Mourning Statue. *A great statue (Saar) weeps rivers of brine that pool in the chamber.*

- Calcified corpses kneel in the waters while, several are positioned as if drinking Saar's tears.
- Robed Cultists (2/hero) and Fanatics (1 for every 2 heroes) invite the characters to drink the water and "join in Saar's misery" becoming increasingly hostile if rebuffed. Heroes who drink become Dehydrated—if all do, the cultists are satisfied and leave them alone.
- Damaging the statue awakens the corpses (3 Zombies/hero).

The Font of Anguish. *An empty basin stands atop a raised dais, whispers emanate from it.*

- Whispers "Brackish and mournful in rivers I flow. Gift unto me and I shall bestow." If tears are placed in the basin, it begins to glow brighter and a Tearstone Drop-let appears inside.

Cult Chambers. *Simple bedchambers littered with salt and 6 small weeping statuettes (Saar).*

- Sat atop a writing desk is Ado's personal tome. It serves as a spellbook, diary, and manifesto on the nature of misery, detailing the loss of his family (they rejected the divinity of Saar) and the path that led him to imbibing the water of the Sea of Tears.
- Within the tome are the incantations required to learn the secret spell: Desiccate, which requires 8 hours of

study with the tome.

- If the heroes take the tome, each of the statuettes begins to shriek in discordant anguish. Each round the heroes remain in this area, they suffer 1 damage/statue (ignoring armor) on a failed DC 13 WIL save. Each statue has 10 HP and heavy armor.

The Sobbing Balcony. *A narrow balcony looks down 50 feet to the worshippers outside the tower. They stare up at you mournfully.*

- When the heroes look down on the captives, they all speak in unison: "Weep with us. There is purpose in everlasting lamentation!"
- The closest hero must make a DC 15 WIL save or they weep uncontrollably and desperately desires to join them as soon as possible, pitching themselves off the balcony (5d6 falling damage if not stopped).

Agency. *Losing control of a hero is not fun! Allow them and one other hero to make an Initiative roll, if faster they can be prevented from falling.*

- Succeed or fail, the worshippers find hope that you could resist (or survive the fall), and will share with you helpful information about The Pale Heart.

CULTISTS



Fanatical Zeal. *Roll with advantage while damaged.*

CULTIST LVL 1

28

Oblation of Blood! (If undamaged) Attack self for 2 damage and afflict adjacent enemies with Despair. Otherwise choose 1:

- **Blood Boil.** (Range 12, Bloodied creature) 3d6+6.
- **Dreadful Blade.** 1d6+6. On crit inflict Despair.

Despair. *Disadvantage on your next roll this encounter.*

FANATIC LVL 3

41

Oblation of Blood! (If undamaged) Attack self for 2 damage and afflict adjacent enemies with Despair. Otherwise choose 1:

- **Ecstatic Grip.** 1d6+6. On damage, gain Riding. (escape DC 12, or any radiant damage)
- **Whispers of Madness.** Deal 3d6+6 unpreventable psychic damage to a creature you are Riding.

DOOMSAYER LVL 5

58

- **Feverish Chant.** (Concentration) Reduce all damage done to allies who can hear you to 1. OR:
- **Ecstatic Ravings.** 2d6 psychic damage to all enemies who can hear you.

The Pale Heart. *Hovering above the central chamber is a pallid crystal. Tending to it, a group of men in pale robes: 1 Fanatic (Ado the Dessicated), 2 Cultists/hero, and 1 Doomsayer (with 20 hp/hero).*

"Have you come to witness the rebirth of our Lady Misery? The time is nigh."

What Ado Wants:

- For others to "see the beauty of misery."
- To gain more followers. He is happy to answer their questions and tell them any remaining Secrets. He's mad with eldritch influence after all!
- "Will you weep with us, or will you die?"

When these cultists are defeated the crystal shatters and the people outside the tower are freed from its magical control. However, it also causes the tower to begin collapsing!

SKILL CHALLENGE: ESCAPE!

The heroes will need to escape before the tower collapses. This series of dangers will need to be navigated creatively with skill checks in order to succeed.

Skill Challenge. *Allow 1 hero per room to describe an idea of how they help the party navigate the danger then make an appropriate skill check to see how well their idea worked out. If the hero's idea is particularly good (e.g., if they spend some limited resource, use an item, or other ability) you can give them advantage or even let them succeed automatically.*

- **The Pale Heart.** The roof begins to cave in threatening to crush you! What do you do? (DC 12)
- **Cult Chambers.** The statues (or their shattered remains, if already defeated) are shrieking, it's difficult to think straight, or tell which way to go (DC 13; roll with disadvantage if the statues were not defeated previously).
- **The Sobbing Balcony.** The balcony has collapsed and a pillar blocks access. Heroes glimpse the multitudes below—unconscious, and in grave danger.
- **The Font of Anguish.** The font gushes tears, flooding the room. Waist-high water sloshing about makes it almost impossible to move through (DC 14).
- **Mourning Statue.** The statue of Saar collapses, awakening the undead corpses that attempt to Grapple the heroes as they pass (ALL heroes, escape DC 8). Any remaining cultists are unceremoniously crushed by the collapsing statue.
- **Shards of Sorrow.** The stalagmites fall, room is filled with a fine salt dust, burns the eyes and

temporarily blinding all who pass through (DC 16).

- **Saline Protector.** The last hero to make it out must pass a DC 18 skill check or lose all of their remaining HP and suffer 2 Wounds as they're pinned under rubble (If the Salt Golems live, they roll with disadvantage). Another hero can heroically intervene, taking the damage and Wounds in their stead.

SKILL CHALLENGE: AFTERMATH

- **3 or fewer failures.** You are able to escape in time and rescue all of the unconscious civilians outside the tower! Resounding success, you are hailed as heroes and your reputation grows throughout the region. The survivors are able to pull together the princely sum of **250 gp/hero** in gratitude for being saved from the cultish prison of the white tower.

- **4+ failures.** You escape with your lives, but just barely. The tower collapses, taking a third of the former worshippers with it. The remaining civilians outside thank you profusely for saving them as they come to, but you have to think if you were just a bit faster, maybe you could have saved more of them? The survivors are able to scrounge up a disappointing **120 gp/hero** in exchange for freeing them.

- If the cult is defeated, the people outside are freed from the tower's thrall and the world is spared Saar's misery.

- **Failure.** If Ado is allowed to continue his rituals, the Tower of Salt grows ever-taller and a curse of sorrow begins to engulf the land. Before long, even the sun and moon cry down onto the earth.

